推拉

Gregory Nero

***Abstract*—amidoingsomethingthaticareabout? i ask myself this on the plane back from taipei. the dark, timeless cabin echos with that question. some moments feel extra pivotal.**

***Index Terms*—big, changes, coming, (again)**

PEERING

So this is six years of Hummingbird Drama, eh? Six years ago on my front porch in the middle of the pandemic I started this adventure. I would watch the hummingbirds at the feeder and wait for change to come. I find myself at the precipice of yet another gigantic life transition. I've just finished graduate school and a short post-doc appointment here at the University of Arizona. I started here in August 2020, and August 2026 is approaching at a blinding speed. In September I'm slated to move to Taipei, Taiwan to begin another post-doc there. I will frankly say it: I have never been more unsure of exactly what I want to do with this thing called a career. In the last few years I've been emerging more into my own politics and view of the world which has, to put it briefly, made job hunting more complicated. I now move very carefully and intentionally. What is my role as a scientist in this day and age? What does meaningful work in optics look like? How do I navigate a job market without being complicit in the stranglehold that big tech and militarization have on both the public and private sectors of my work? There is no fairy-tale scientific lab where work happens in a vacuum, apart from the social and political implications of that work. In a way, I have become less interested in the technical work and more interested in these aforementioned implications of it: who is doing the research, who is funding it, for what, and to accomplish what ends? These questions wrap me in their web. My only regret is that I didn't start asking these questions earlier. But, alas, I'm here now and although it has been more challenging, I see no other way of proceeding. As a scientist, I'm compelled to search for reason and truth in all things, both technical and social. This is my red pill moment. And, to top it off, I'm about to turn 30 (29 comes first). So, like, what better moment for me to question everything that I've been doing up to this point and maybe make some drastic and life-altering change because of these questions? That's what your 30's are for, right?

As for this project: I have no intention of stopping. I don't know what it will morph into, how it will adapt to my creative visions (ravings?), how I will change it and how it will subsequently change me. It is a companion now, a trusted one. All I know is that I fucking love writing and that I have ideas. The rest will have to work itself out naturally.

ANOTHER MESSY AND BEAUTIFUL COLLECTION OF THOUGHTS AND MEMORIES

In my dreams, I peer through the small gap in the basement refrigerator. I draw it for you in your notebook. Later in my dreams we are there, laying where I remember laying by the stove, and Pearl is pissing on the bricks. *What happens when the mind relieves itself of a burden?* In the metal sink, Dad fillets the bluegills with a mechanical saw. I never saw the guts. I remember a nightmare I had when I was younger in that same basement area. Dark shadow, looming, stasis.

I play you a song on my nose whistle and we giggle about small noises and other beautiful things. Blended fruit and yellow, runny yolk become a seductive love poem. We talk about the future on a Very Large Rock. We talk about *our* future on a Very Large Rock. The Very Large Rock hold us above the river and all of a sudden anything is possible with you. We open our pasture and keep in spacious. I love the ways we blossom together.

When I was younger I would smash coins with a hammer and a vice grip in the garage. Pound and squish out the patterns until the metal is smooth and clean. *What am I supposed to do about this parade of angst behind me?* I want to text you "what happened?" without realizing you've already given me the answer. Somewhere in the parade line a small figure jumps out of step and skips off into another street. (Insert some shit about the wisdom accumulated from being in your late 20's). I buy a Circle K Polar Pop and fill it all the way up with ice and yellow and blue liquid. My phone overheats and my internet dies while I try to complete an Uber Eats order. I witness him gently lift the spirit from the feather before she picks it up. I have this urge to empty out my room as much as possible. I wait for some rain.